

DANGEROUS ICON Amritpal Singh in his current avatar; left, as a well-groomed, short-haired businessman in Dubai

Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH

AMRITPAL SEAMLESSLY MOVED INTO THE VACUUM OF PUNJAB'S PANTHIC POLITICS BY PLAYING ON THE MANY GRIEVANCES OF THE YOUTH

over Waris as its chief in August 2022, presented a starkly different person. Gone was the jeans-clad, fluently Anglophone youth. In his place stood a traditional Sikh religious leader, at least in attire and bearing. He also re-fashioned Waris as a pro-Khalistani outfit. He partook of *amrit* (a baptism ceremony) and by September-end did *dastar bandi* (turban-tying ceremony) at Rode village in Moga—the ancestral village of slain militant Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale. In the ceremony, Amritpal dressed like his avowed idol—in a long *bana* shirt and electric blue *dumala* turban.

Soon, in November 2022, Amritpal embarked on a *Khalsa Vaheer*, or march, across Punjab to spread Sikhism, and conducted programmes of *amrit sanchar*, where many formally became part of the Khalsa order. In his sermons, Amritpal professed to follow in Bhindranwale's path. He spoke openly about Khalistan and encouraged his supporters to carry arms for the 'Sikh cause' and be ready for 'sacrifice'. His popularity as a role model grew exponentially among youth disgruntled with shrinking economic opportunities and left feeling anchorless by the churn in the state's *panthic* politics. Amritpal seamlessly moved into this vacuum, turning every grievance into an allegation of racial targeting. So, drugs, he claimed, were smuggled into Punjab as a conspiracy to 'eliminate' Sikhs and erode Punjabi culture. He put the demand for a 'Hindu rashtra' with that for Khalistan on the same footing. For good measure, there was resonant atavism: appeal of a life of purity, a 'fight for freedom', a deliverance from 'slavery'.

However, despite the similar-sounding rhetoric, Amritpal is no Bhindranwale. The latter was steeped in Sikh scriptural and theological knowledge, having joined a seminary at a young age and becoming the 14th jathedar of the Damdami Taksal in 1977, a religious school made famous by him. Denouncing practices such as dowry, he preached the path of social reform and urged youth to eschew consumerism, abstain from intoxicants and return to the path of the Khalsa. He pushed more for the implementation of the Anandpur Sahib Resolution of 1973, which demanded greater autonomy for Punjab. It would take Bhindranwale over six years and many confrontations with the central and state government to gain an iconic status among Sikh militants. Amritpal may have the agency of social media to spread his belief, but currently he is nothing more than a start-up and does not have a pan-Punjab influence. Nor do the people of Punjab have any appetite for separatism anymore. What Amritpal does have is the potential to create unrest. The police probe into Hindutva radical leader Sudhir Suri's murder found that assailant Sandeep Singh was influenced by Amritpal.

Other radical Sikh groups regard Amritpal with suspicion. Some call him '*agenciyan da banda*' or a spy of the security agencies. Either way, he can stir trouble, that's for sure. ■